If India and China do once again fight a war over their borderlands in Ladakh and Arunachal Pradesh, a lot of the world will wonder why. Only three countries – Pakistan, India, and China – have thought it sensible to fight at the impossible heights that are contested in some stretches of territory. Pakistan and India have subjected their soldiers to a fearful life on the Siachen glacier at elevations of 5400 metres above sea level. Temperatures there can fall to minus 50 degrees Celsius. India and China have fought at similar elevations and could do so again, in similar temperatures. The air in these places is so thin that sustained activity can cause pulmonary oedema leading to death – you drown in the water that collects in the pouches in your lungs. Indian and Chinese soldiers could die trying to fight rather than die in an actual fight.

Yet, strategists constantly tell us that there are real military objectives in these places. Some seem sensible and some seem phantasmagorical. Here are the phantasmagorical: that if Pakistan controls the Siachen glacier it could seriously threaten India's security in Kashmir; that if India controls the glacier it could bear down meaningfully on the China–Pakistan Karakoram Highway; that if China controls the heights above the Daulet Beg Oldie road it can threaten Indian military moves all the way to China's Karakoram Pass and could eventually link up with Pakistan at – or near – the Siachen glacier and push India off its perch there. Here are the sensible objectives. It is comprehensible that China would want to preserve and protect its road from Xinjiang to Tibet. Aksai Chin therefore becomes strategically important. India by contrast has no great need for control of Aksai Chin. It is comprehensible that India wants control over the southern slopes of the mountains in Arunachal Pradesh since that could be the gateway to the entire North-East. Defending its claims to the McMahon Line is strategically important. China by contrast has no crying need to plant its flag on the southern slopes.

Is this another way of saying that the swap is the correct answer to the border quarrel? The swap deal is probably dead forever: it has got a bad name on both sides of the boundary, and few will dare talk about it publicly. Saying that there are sensible strategic and military objectives is a way of